Great Power Intervention

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On 05 Apr 2023 a high-profile letter from Maurice Greenberg called Presidents Biden and Xi to repair relations between the US and China. The letter, co-signed by a host of US foreign policy and economic experts, appeared in a leading US-based newspaper but was then widely reproduced on Twitter, Facebook, and other social media. Such a call was timely in light of the sharply deteriorating relations between the two Great Powers. There is great concern over the US and China's hardening opposing stances on Taiwan, trade, technology, strategic alliances and spheres of influence, and a range of other important issues.

Some observers asked if Greenberg's letter should have been published in China as well, perhaps additionally signed by Chinese thought leaders. The unspoken inference was not entirely constructive. Instead it was a swipe at how while these discussions are possible in the US, surely they would not be free to take place in China.

Yes, such political conversation might be fairer and more open in some places than others. But the more important question is not what China's thought leaders might have done: It is what all the world's other nations think and want to say.

Eighty percent of the world's population live in neither of the Great Powers, but in Third Nations. US-China tensions affect not just the well-being of the US and China. Everyone on this planet is a stakeholder in geopolitical rivalry.

Today's US-China tensions have disrupted trade, investment, and people-to-people exchange. The upending of long-standing rules of engagement have made the global economy poorer and less stable. Greenberg and co-signers are right to try and stage an intervention in light of continuing Great Power misbehaviour. But that intervention needs its weight magnified and its franchise extended, not just by including Chinese interlocutors but everyone else around the world.

1 Third Nation Agency and Great Power Elasticity

Nations acquire sustained enduring soft power through gaining trust, attractiveness, and legitimacy. This cannot be achieved through the crude exercise of military strength. Instead, sustained soft power derives not directly from one's actions but is awarded by others.

Seeking trust, attractiveness, and legitimacy shifts the centre of gravity of decision-making from those who would deploy power—the supply side of world order—towards those who experience its consequences, the demand side. The same is true for any world order that comprises spheres of influence, is based on the "consent of the governed", or ensures "mutually beneficial, win-win outcomes". Whatever the world order that will emerge, Third Nations are pivotal.

But it is not just right that the focal point of international politics should shift away from Great Powers and towards Third Nations. It is also what works.

Observers of international affairs routinely turn for insight to the ancient Greek historian Thucydides. After all, Thucydides had convincingly proposed the idea that nations that are incumbent powers and those that are rising powers will, with high probability, resort to violence to advance their self-interests. Equally memorably, Thucydides had also suggested that Great Powers do what they will, the rest of us suffer what we must. To this day Realism carries forwards variants of this compelling idea. But, despite this conventional wisdom, history is full of examples of the opposite, i.e., of Third Nation agency and Great Power elasticity, when Third Nations have insisted, and Great Powers have given way.

I give here just three examples.

The largest world grouping after the United Nations is the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM). Established in 1961, NAM was a follow-up to the Bandung Conference which had emerged in response to Western Powers arrogantly putting together policies for Asia without consulting Asian nations themselves. Asian nations were, at that time, also growing in concern over US-China tensions (as now) and seeking platforms for improved relations with the large nations around them (then, as now). NAM, at inception, comprised just 55% of the world's population and two-thirds of UN membership. Today, the collection of Third Nations is far larger. Yet, even the far-smaller NAM is acknowledged to have already achieved significant success in shifting the global consensus on disarmament, opposition to racism, and opposition to apartheid in South Africa.

In the same vein Third Nation organizers behind the Ottawa Treaty managed, by 2022, to get 164 states acceding to Treaty conditions banning anti-personnel mines. Significant exceptions then included the Great Powers: China, to get Russia, and the US. Later that year, however, President Biden followed Third Nations and overturned the policies of the previous US administration, committing to destroy all America's existing landmines.

Finally, a less happy example from Thucydides's own time: the infamous Thucydides Trap did, indeed, embroil the great powers Sparta and Athens in the Pelopponesian

war, resulting in Athens's resounding defeat. However, barely half a decade afterwards, reacting to unbenevolent Spartan hegemony, the states Thebes and Corinth ("the rest of us") waged military uprising against their own former ally Sparta, in the Corinthian War. The great general Epaminondas led Thebes to a resounding victory, crushing Spartan military dominance barely thirty years after the Peloponnesian War, and leaving the once-victorious hegemon isolated and permanently weakened.

2 Staging an Intervention

The world does not have to undergo modern-day counterparts of the Peloponnesian and Corinthian Wars. If the Great Powers are unable to see through their zero-sum disagreements, it is up to Third Nations to stage an intervention, to pull the Great Powers back from the disaster that could emerge for all.

This is not to discount the importance of Great Power leadership, even as matters look grim. Half a century ago Nixon's trip to China unimaginably transformed for the better the world's international relations, and with most unlikely beginnings. Nixon was a McCarthyist with solid anti-Communist credentials. China had killed tens of millions of its own people in the Cultural Revolution through purges, disruption, and starvation, and actively sought to export revolution across Southeast Asia. But despite this distance between them, Nixon reached out to Mao, acknowledging how "we simply cannot afford to leave China forever outside the family of nations, there to nurture its fantasies, cherish its hates, and threaten its neighbors. There is no place on this small planet for a billion of its potentially most able people to live in angry isolation."

Nixon and Mao's coming together was an act of extraordinary political bravery and leadership. Today America could be a far richer place if it allowed China's continued manufacturing prowess, not just in iPhones but in planet-saving green energy capacity; fifty years ago America did not need China in this way. Then China was truly a dangerous place promoting internal turmoil and external threats of revolution; today it does none of those things. Compared to fifty years ago, with reality now so much better than then, the greatest tragedy and irony would unfold if both Great Powers do not reverse their direction of heightening rivalry.

More than ever, we could again use a Nixon-Mao-esque leadership. But if that is not forthcoming, Third Nations will just have to step up and stage a badly-needed Great Power intervention.